HRSA
Health Resources & Services Administration

What's New in the Area Health Resources Files

2024 – 2025 Release

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Introduction

The Health Resources and Services Administration (HRSA) of the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (DHHS) releases a new version of the Area Health Resources Files (AHRF) annually. The 2024–2025 Area Health Resources Files are the most current release and provide the latest health resource needs and supply data available. These files include extensive data on health professions and sociodemographic characteristics available at the county level as well as broader data on health professions and demographic, workforce, and training characteristics available at the state and national levels. Although these data have been made available annually for many years, the content and formats are different on recent releases, particularly for the county-level file.

The 2024–2025 AHRF contains a number of changes introduced in the 2022–2023 release that were designed to help a range of audiences use the data more easily. These enhancements include the following:

- The provision of new, unique variable identifiers
- The availability of data in additional formats
- The addition of smaller, more focused subset files
- The elimination of redundant data
- Expanded documentation to provide crosswalks between earlier file-naming conventions and new variable names, as well as more explanatory notes

Also new starting with the 2023–2024 AHRF is the inclusion of additional records for the state of Connecticut, which now reports data at the Planning Region, rather than county, level. Beginning with data being reported for 2022 and later, the U.S. Census started reporting Connecticut data by the nine designated Planning Regions rather than the eight counties. Other data sources have also begun to adopt reporting data for Connecticut at this geographic level.

This document describes in some detail the differences within the 2024–2025 AHRF. Users familiar with AHRF products over time will notice marked differences in the current components as compared with previous releases. In the sections that follow, we describe both the composition of the 2024–2025 AHRF products and the differences between the new release and earlier releases.

What's New

AHRF data enhancements

In an effort to make the AHRF data more accessible and easier to use for a broader range of users, HRSA incorporated a number of enhancements into the AHRF products beginning with the 2022–2023 AHRF. The major enhancements include the following:

1. The 2024–2025 AHRF includes files in multiple formats.
2. The new county AHRF includes only the most recent two years of data for each variable, largely eliminating redundant historical data across releases and making the file a more manageable size
3. The most current data available are provided for those data sources that are updated regularly; these can be combined with earlier releases of the AHRF to analyze change across time.
4. To also reduce file size and facilitate use, HRSA created seven focused subsets of the county file for users to easily access specific targeted subsets of data in CSV format. These include:
   - Codes and classifications
   - Health professions
   - Health facilities
   - Utilization
   - Expenditures
   - Population
   - Environment
5. The 2024–2025 version of the AHRF files contains a new set of data element names that are more descriptive of the elements than the Field number used in releases prior to 2022–2023. The variable-naming convention also provides details of the characteristics of the data variable. The AHRF documentation includes a crosswalk between these conventions and describes how to navigate between the new release and earlier releases.

Updates to the AHRF data

County file updates

As noted above, effective with the 2023–2024 release, the AHRF now includes nine additional records for the state of Connecticut. The additional records represent the state's Councils of Governments and Planning Regions. The Census Bureau adopted these nine Planning Regions as the county-equivalent geographic units for the purpose of collecting, tabulating, and disseminating statistical data beginning with data year 2022. Starting with the 2023–2024 AHRF release, data for specific variables are included for the Connecticut counties or for the county-equivalent Planning Regions, depending on which geographic unit each specific data source reports.

In the 2024–2025 release, the AHRF incorporates the 2024 County Adjacency File from the U.S. Census Bureau to identify the 14 contiguous counties for each county in the data set. These variables provide the

Federal Information Processing System (FIPS) state and county codes for all neighboring counties. In previous versions, this information was based on data from the U.S. Department of Commerce, Bureau of the Census—specifically the *Map of Boundaries of Counties and County Equivalents as of January 1, 1970* (U.S. Government Printing Office, 1971, Stock Number 0424798)—and was updated manually each year. This update aligns the AHRF with a more current and consistently maintainable data source.

Also beginning with the 2024–2025 AHRF, contiguous county fields for Connecticut Planning Region records are included as they are available from the 2024 County Adjacency File. Records from the eight Connecticut counties and the former Valdez-Cordova Census Area (FIPS code 02261) are blank.

Relative to the 2022–2023 release of the AHRF, we adjusted 14 variable names in the county-level files in the 2023–2024 and 2024–2025 AHRF. These changes were to align the variable name with the goals of the new variable-naming convention implemented with the 2022–2023 release and make the variables internally consistent with other variables from the same data source. The 14 variables with differing names from the 2022–2023 release are noted in Table 1.

Table 1. New variable names relative to the 2022–2023 AHRF

FIELD_OLD_NAME	FIELD_NEW_NAME23 (2022–2023 variable name)	FIELD_NEW_NAME24 (2023–2024 variable name)
F11273-21	md_fed_gp_pc_rsdnt_21	md_fed_all_gp_pc_rsdnt_21
F11274-21	md_fed_gp_pc_hosp_ft_21	md_fed_all_gp_pc_hosp_ft_21
F11275-21	md_fed_gp_othprofl_21	md_fed_all_gp_othprofl_21
F11279-21	md_fed_genintmed_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_genintmed_othprofl_21
F11291-21	md_fed_gen_surg_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_gen_surg_othprofl_21
F11299-21	md_fed_othsurgsub_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_othsurgsub_othprofl_21
F11303-21	md_fed_psych_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_psych_othprofl_21
F11307-21	md_fed_oth_subsp_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_oth_subsp_othprofl_21
F11737-21	md_fed_gen_ped_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_gen_ped_othprofl_21
F11741-21	md_fed_othmedsub_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_othmedsub_othprofl_21
F11743-21	md_fed_gen_obgyn_pc_rsdnt_21	md_fed_obgyn_gen_pc_rsdnt_21
F11744-21	md_fed_gen_obgyn_pc_hosp_ft_21	md_fed_obgyn_gen_pc_hosp_ft_21
F11745-21	md_fed_gen_obgyn_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_obgyn_gen_othprofl_21
F11749-21	md_fed_obgyn_subs_pc_othprofl_21	md_fed_obgyn_subs_othprofl_21

Lastly, in the 2024–2025 release of the AHRF, we added 47 new variables derived from the American Medical Association Physician Professional Data. These variables include total counts of all Doctors of Medicine (MDs) and Doctors of Osteopathic Medicine (DOs) (Federal and non-Federal), total counts of all active MDs and DOs (Federal and non-Federal), and total counts of all active MDs and DOs by physician specialty across 45 categories. We made this enhancement in response to user feedback requesting more comprehensive physician counts at a higher aggregation level than previously available. Table 2 shows a complete list of the 47 new variables.

Table 2. New AMA variables in the 2024–2025 AHRF

New variable in the 2024–2025 AHRF	FIELD_NEW_NAME25 (2024–2025 variable name)
Total physicians	
Total	tot_md_do_23
Total active	tot_md_do_activ_23
Total physicians, by physician specialty	
Allergy & Immunology, Total	tot_md_do_allergy_23
Aerospace Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_aero_med_23
Anesthesiology, Total	tot_md_do_anesth_23
Cardiovascular Disease, Total	tot_md_do_card_dis_23
Child Psychiatry Total	tot_md_do_child_psych_23
Colon/Rectal Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_colrct_surg_23
Dermatology, Total	tot_md_do_derm_23
Diagnostic Radiology, Total	tot_md_do_diag_radlgy_23
Emergency Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_emerg_med_23
Family Medicine Gen, Total	tot_md_do_fammed_gen_23
Family Medicine Subspecialties, Total	tot_md_do_fammed_subsp_23
Forensic Pathology, Total	tot_md_do_foren_path_23
Gastroenterology, Total	tot_md_do_gastr_23
General Practitioner, Total	tot_md_do_gp_23
General Preventive Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_genprevmed_23
General Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_gen_surg_23
General Internal Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_genintmed_23
Internal Medicine Subspecialties, Total	tot_md_do_intmed_subsp_23
Medical Genetics, Total	tot_md_do_med_gentcs_23
Neurology, Total	tot_md_do_neuro_23
Nuclear Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_nuclr_med_23
Neurological Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_neuro_surg_23
Ob-Gyn, General, Total	tot_md_do_obgyn_gen_23
Ob-Gyn Subspecialties, Total	tot_md_do_obgyn_subsp_23
Occupational Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_occl_med_23
Ophthalmology, Total	tot_md_do_ophth_23
Orthopedic Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_ortho_23
Other Specialties, Total	tot_md_do_oth_spec_23
Otolaryngology, Total	tot_md_do_otolryn_23
Psychiatry, Total	tot_md_do_psych_23
Pediatrics, General, Total	tot_md_do_ped_gen_23
Pediatric Cardiology, Total	tot_md_do_ped_card_23
Pediatric Subspecialty, Total	tot_md_do_ped_subsp_23
Public Health/General Preventive Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_publc_hlth_23

New variable in the 2024–2025 AHRF	FIELD_NEW_NAME25 (2024–2025 variable name)
Physical Medicine/Rehabilitation, Total	tot_md_do_pmrehab_23
Plastic Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_plas_surg_23
Pathology, Anatomic/Clinical, Total	tot_md_do_anat_path_23
Pulmonary Disease, Total	tot_md_do_pulm_dis_23
Radiology, Total	tot_md_do_radlgy_23
Radiation Oncology, Total	tot_md_do_rad_oncolgy_23
Thoracic Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_thor_surg_23
Transplant Surgery, Total	tot_md_do_transpl_surg_23
Urology, Total	tot_md_do_urolgy_23
Unspecified, Total	tot_md_do_unspec_23
Vascular Medicine, Total	tot_md_do_vasc_med_23

State and national file update

In the 2024–2025 release of the AHRF, we added 18 new variables derived from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) file from the National Center for Education Statistics, U.S. Department of Education (Table 3). These variables include counts of degrees awarded in health professions by level of award. In previous releases, the AHRF included only a select set of award-level variables. With this update, the file now includes all available award levels, providing a more comprehensive view of education in the health professions nationally and across states.

Table 3. New IPEDS variables in the 2024–2025 AHRF

New variable in the 2024–2025 AHRF	FIELD_NEW_NAME25 (2024–2025 variable name)
Physicians, Post-Master's Certificate	phys_post_mastrs_23
LP/LVN, Post-Baccalaureate Certificate	lpnlvn_postbc_cert_23
LP/LVN, Post-Master's Certificate	lpnlvn_post_mastrs_23
Dental Hygienists, Post-Baccalaureate Certificate	dent_hygn_postbc_cert_23
Dental Hygienists, Post-Master's Certificate	dent_hygn_post_mastrs_23
Pharmacists, Associate's	pharm_assocts_23
Pharmacists, Post-Baccalaureate Certificate	pharm_postbc_cert_23
Veterinarians, Post-Master's Certificate	vetin_post_mastrs_23
Social Workers, More than 2 Less than 4 Years	socwk_2_4yrs_23
PT Assistants/Aides, Master's	pt_asst_mastrs_23
PT Assistants/Aides, Post-Master's Certificate	pt_asst_post_mastrs_23
Respiratory Therapists, Post-Baccalaureate Certificate	resp_ther_postbc_cert_23
Dietitians and Nutritionists, More than 2 Less than 4 Years	dietn_2_4yrs_23
Clinical Lab Technologist/Technicians, Post-Master's Certificate	clin_lab_techs_post_mastrs_23
Diagnostic Related Technologist/Technicians, Post-Master's Certificate	diag_reltd_techs_post_mastrs_23

New variable in the 2024–2025 AHRF	FIELD_NEW_NAME25 (2024–2025 variable name)
Medical Records Specialists, Doctoral	med_rec_spec_doctrl_23
APRN, Less than 1 Year	aprn_educ_lt1yr_23
Occupational Therapists Assistants, Less than 1 Year	ot_asst_educ_lt1yr_23

Accessing and Using the 2024–2025 AHRF Data

The 2024–2025 release of the AHRF is available in two formats: CSV and as a SAS data set. Support documentation is provided.

Users can access the AHRF products through the HRSA Data Warehouse – Data Downloads website (https://data.hrsa.gov/data/download). On the AHRF page, users can download data by selecting from the available options: county-level or state/national files, SAS or CSV formats, and documentation.

Users interested in a specific set of data variables (for example, physicians) can select the associated subfile (such as Health Professions) and obtain only that subset of data from the complete county file. Similarly, users can select other subsets based on specific data needs.

Due to changes in the 2024–2025 release compared with earlier versions, users should be aware that formats, variable names, and data characteristics may have changed. It is recommended to consult prior documentation when comparing this release to earlier versions.

Working with CSV files

CSV is a simple and widely supported format that requires minimal additional specifications. Each record appears on a single line, with variable names in the first row. All variables and values are separated by commas, and values containing special characters (such as commas or quotation marks) are enclosed in double quotes. The CSV format can accommodate many users and their tool of choice. CSV files are compatible with most statistical software packages, including Stata, R, and Python, many of which offer point-and-click import tools.

Table 4 includes example code for reading CSV files in various programming languages on a Windows PC.

Table 4. Example code for importing CSV files in common programming languages

Programming language	Example code
Stata	import delimited "c\test\file.csv
R	Read csv = read.csv('c:\\test\file.csv', header=TRUE)
Python	Import pandas as pd df=pd.read csv('c:\\test\file.csv', sep=",")

Support Documentation

AHRF documentation has been expanded to offer users more information and easier access to the information.

AHRF User Documentation

The 2024–2025 AHRF User Documentation focuses on the data sources and specific data variables that comprise the AHRF county-level and the state/national files. Data sources and variable definitions offer clear descriptions of the data as well as information on further breakdowns of the data by subcategory (for example, short-term general hospital, office-based physician by specialty). The documentation also provides details on the sources of the data, including name of the source data file, year of the data, suppression, and any anomalies or restrictions on the data imposed by the data source. For example, data suppression is applied as dictated by the specific data sources and will vary from source to source.

AHRF Technical Documentation

The 2024–2025 AHRF Technical Documentation lists each data element included in the files. Technical descriptor information for each data element is as follows:

Field	New variable name of the data element
Data Category	Category of data on the CSV file/subfile
Year of Data	Year of the data
Variable Name	Full name of the data element
Characteristics	Additional descriptors of the data
Source	Name of the original data source
Date On	Date the data variable was first included in the AHRF

The name and characteristics of the data element can be inferred from the new name. The State/National Technical Documentation includes the same presentation as shown above, including New Names.